

# Spain Itinerary – Aug 27 to Sep 11, 2026

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### ! Important

**Before you leave:** register for the Camino Frances / Pilgrim Pass at [cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/preregistration](https://cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/preregistration) to get the QR code required for check-in at Roncesvalles (and other participating albergues along the Way).

## Itinerary

### Day 1 – Thu Aug 27

- Drive Grand Rapids → ORD (~2h45m–3h15m); park at **PreFlight Airport Parking ORD** (pre-booked online).
- Chicago ORD → Madrid (Iberia IB 342, Business, dep 4:55 pm, arr Aug 28 8:20 am)

### Day 2 – Fri Aug 28

- 08:20 — Arrive Madrid Barajas T4.
- 10:32 — Depart Madrid–Puerta de Atocha (ALVIA, Localizador **YNPLW2**) → Pamplona/Iruña.
- Transfer Pamplona → Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port (taxi/bus — see Trip References for Taxi Asier contact).
- Check-in: **Gîte de la Porte Saint Jacques** (Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port).
- Pick up pilgrim credential in SJPP if not already obtained.

#### **i** Note

Notes — Aug 28

### Day 3 – Sat Aug 29 (Camino Day 1)

- **Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port → Roncesvalles** (~25 km / 15.5 mi) — the Napoleon Route over the Pyrenees.
  - Route highlights: steep climb out of SJPP past Refuge Orisson; the Virgin of Biakorri statue; the high ridge crossing the France–Spain border with sweeping Pyrenees views; descent through beech forest at Col de Lepoeder into Roncesvalles’ Collegiate Church and monastery.
- Show QR code / passport at check-in. Albergue closes at 22:00; reservation held until 19:00 unless later arrival is flagged.
- Dinner seating 20:30.
- Overnight: **Albergue de Peregrinos de Orreaga-Roncesvalles** (Localizador **AL08344890**).

 **Caution**

**This is the hardest and most exposed day of the entire Camino** (~1,200 m climb, few bailout points), done one day after a transatlantic flight and jet lag. Start at first light. Check weather the night before — in fog, high wind, or rain, take the lower **Valcarlos route** instead (~19 km, road-based, far less exposure); ask at the SJPP pilgrim office. Carry rain layer, poles, and food/water since services on the Napoleon route are minimal.

**Days 4–14 – Aug 30 to Sep 9 (Camino Francés – Roncesvalles to Burgos)**

- **Day 4 (Aug 30):** Roncesvalles → Zubiri (~21.5 km / 13.4 mi)
  - Route highlights: descent through Auritz/Burguete (the village where Hemingway stayed and wrote of trout fishing in *The Sun Also Rises*); Roncesvalles pass and Erro valley beech forest; Alto de Erro; drop into Zubiri over the medieval Puente de la Rabia.
- **Day 5 (Aug 31):** Zubiri → Pamplona (~20.4 km / 12.7 mi)
  - Route highlights: riverside path along the Río Arga; Larrasoaña; the Romanesque Trinidad de Arre bridge marking the entry into greater Pamplona; Pamplona's old town, Plaza del Castillo, and the Gothic cathedral.
- **Day 6 (Sep 1):** Pamplona → Puente la Reina (~23.8 km / 14.8 mi)
  - Route highlights: Alto del Perdón ridge — wind turbines and the famous silhouette-of-pilgrims sculpture with panoramic views over Navarra; Uterga and Muruzábal; Puente la Reina's iconic 11th-century Romanesque bridge, where the Camino Francés and Camino Aragonés merge.
- **Day 7 (Sep 2):** Puente la Reina → Estella (~21.5 km / 13.4 mi)
  - Route highlights: hilltop medieval village of Cirauqui with a stretch of original Roman road below it; Lorca and Villatuerta; Estella/Lizarra's Palacio de los Reyes de Navarra and the church of San Pedro de la Rúa.
- **Day 8 (Sep 3):** Estella → Los Arcos (~21.3 km / 13.2 mi)
  - Route highlights: Bodegas Irache's free pilgrim wine fountain (Fuente del Vino) right on the trail; Monasterio de Irache; Villamayor de Monjardín beneath its hilltop castle ruins; Los Arcos and the ornate church of Santa María.
- **Day 9 (Sep 4):** Los Arcos → Logroño (~27.5 km / 17.1 mi) — long and largely shadeless through vineyard country; start at dawn.

- Route highlights: Sansol and Torres del Río’s octagonal, Templar-linked Church of the Holy Sepulchre; crossing from Navarra into La Rioja; Viana’s old town; entering Logroño — Rioja’s wine capital — over the Puente de Piedra and into the Calle Laurel tapas district.
- **Day 10 (Sep 5):** Logroño → Nájera (~29 km / 18.0 mi) — longest stage of the trip, same exposed terrain; start at dawn, carry extra water.
  - Route highlights: Parque de la Grajera reservoir just outside Logroño; Navarrete’s vineyards and pottery tradition; Nájera’s cliffside setting above the Río Najerilla and the royal pantheon in the Monasterio de Santa María la Real.
- **Day 11 (Sep 6):** Nájera → Santo Domingo de la Calzada (~21 km / 13.0 mi)
  - Route highlights: Azofra and Cirueña; Santo Domingo de la Calzada’s cathedral, famous for keeping a live rooster and hen inside in honor of the town’s “hanged pilgrim” legend.
- **Day 12 (Sep 7):** Santo Domingo de la Calzada → Belorado (~22.8 km / 14.2 mi)
  - Route highlights: hilltop Grañón with views back over the Rioja plain; crossing from La Rioja into Castilla y León near Redecilla del Camino; Vitoria de Rioja, birthplace of Santo Domingo; Belorado’s old quarter and nearby cave dwellings.
- **Day 13 (Sep 8):** Belorado → San Juan de Ortega (~23.7 km / 14.7 mi)
  - Route highlights: Villafranca Montes de Oca, the last village before a long climb into the Montes de Oca oak and pine forest (historically the most dangerous stretch of the Camino for robbers); the remote Romanesque monastery at San Juan de Ortega, known for a twice-yearly light phenomenon illuminating a capital inside the church at the equinoxes.
- **Day 14 (Sep 9):** San Juan de Ortega → Burgos (~25.8 km / 16.0 mi)
  - Route highlights: Agés and Atapuerca, site of a UNESCO World Heritage archaeological complex with some of the oldest hominid fossils in Europe; the terrain opens into flatter farmland on the approach to Burgos (a preview of the Meseta beyond); Burgos’s Gothic cathedral — a UNESCO World Heritage Site — and El Cid’s tomb in the old town.

## Day 15 – Thu Sep 10

- Burgos → Madrid (train/bus, ~2.5–3 hrs — book once travel day is confirmed).
- Overnight near Madrid (airport-side, ahead of the 11:45 am flight).

## **Day 16 – Fri Sep 11**

- Madrid → Chicago ORD (Iberia IB 341, Business, dep 11:45 am, arr 2:25 pm).
  - Shuttle back to PreFlight lot, drive ORD → Grand Rapids (~2h45m–3h15m).
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## **Packing List**

### **Documents & Money**

- Passport
- Pilgrim credential (credencial) — get stamped daily
- Pilgrim Pass QR code (register before departure, see note above)
- Flight, train & lodging confirmations (digital copies on phone)
- Credit + ATM cards
- Euro cash (small bills for albergues, donativos)

### **Pack Setup**

- Backpack with rain cover (35–40L)
- 1 small dry sack (electronics/passport)
- Packing cubes + plastic bags (organization, laundry separation)

### **Clothing**

- 2 quick-dry short-sleeve tees
- 1 long-sleeve thermal / light layer (cool mornings crossing the Pyrenees on Day 1)
- 1 light fleece or packable insulated layer
- 1 lightweight rain jacket
- 1 convertible hiking pant
- 1 pair town/casual pants or shorts
- 3 pairs quick-dry underwear
- 3 pairs hiking socks (merino blend)

### **Footwear**

- Trail runners or light hiking shoes (broken in well before the trip)
- Lightweight sandals or flip-flops (evenings)

## Toiletries

- Toothbrush + travel toothpaste
- Small liquid soap (body + laundry, e.g. Dr. Bronner's)
- Travel deodorant
- Quick-dry towel
- Sunscreen (August sun is strong, especially crossing the Meseta near Burgos)
- Lip balm with SPF

## Health & First Aid

- Blister pads (Compeed-style hydrocolloid) — essential for Day 1's Pyrenees crossing
- Ibuprofen / acetaminophen / personal medications
- Hand sanitizer, tissues
- Earplugs + eye mask (shared albergue dorms)
- Trekking poles (recommended for the SJPP–Roncesvalles descent)

## Electronics

- iPhone + USB-C cord
- EU plug adapter
- AirPods
- Portable power bank

## Other

- Sunglasses
- Sun hat
- Sleep sack / liner (albergue bedding varies)
- 2 × 1L water bottles (heat + climb on Day 1 demand real hydration capacity)
- Pen (credencial stamps, customs form on the flight home)

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## Trip References (Bookings & Contacts)

### Flights

- **Aug 27 — ORD → MAD (Iberia IB 342, Business)** — dep 4:55 pm Aug 27, arr 8:20 am Aug 28.

- **Sep 11 — MAD → ORD (Iberia IB 341, Business)** — dep 11:45 am, arr 2:25 pm.

## Trains

- **Aug 28 — Madrid Puerta de Atocha → Pamplona/Iruña (ALVIA)** — dep 10:32 am.
  - Localizador: **YNPLW2** | Importe: €81.65 | 1 billete

## Ground Transport

- **Grand Rapids → ORD parking (Aug 27 – Sep 11, 15 days)**
  - PreFlight Airport Parking ORD — pre-booked rate \$9.95/day (~\$149 total) | free 24/7 shuttle every 5–10 min | 4.5 (1,346 reviews) | EV charging available
  - Book online in advance (pre-booked rate vs. \$12.95/day walk-up) — confirm shuttle covers Terminal 5 (Iberia’s terminal) at booking
- **Pamplona → Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port**
  - Taxi de confianza Roncesvalles / Taxi Asier: info@taxiasier.com / +34 670 61 61 90 / www.taxiasier.com (also covers SJPP Roncesvalles airport/train station, 9-seater)

## Lodging

- **Aug 28 — Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port: Gîte de la Porte Saint Jacques**
  - Address: 51 rue de la Citadelle, Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port, France 64220
  - Check-in Fri Aug 28 → Check-out Sat Aug 29
  - Booking.com reservation #**6828058341** | €49 paid
- **Aug 29 — Roncesvalles: Albergue de Peregrinos de Orreaga-Roncesvalles**
  - Address: Carretera N-135, s/n, Roncesvalles, Navarra 31650
  - Phone: +34 948 760 000 | info@alberguederoncesvalles.com | www.alberguederoncesvalles.com
  - Localizador: **AL08344890** | €35 (alojamiento, cena y desayuno)
  - Dinner seating 20:30. Doors close 22:00. Reservation held until 19:00 unless late arrival is flagged.
  - Passport/ID required at check-in for every guest on the reservation.
  - Pilgrim Pass QR code required — register in advance: [cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/pre-registration](https://cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/pre-registration)

### **To Be Booked**

- Lodging for Aug 30 – Sep 9 (Camino stages, Zubiri through Burgos) — book a day or two ahead given peak August demand.
- Burgos → Madrid transport for Sep 10.
- Madrid lodging for the night of Sep 10.